An Roinn Oideachais agus Óige
Department of Education and Youth



Primary School Survey – Results Summary Report

June 2026



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1 Introduction

On 4 November 2025, the Department of Education and Youth published a ‘Framework and Action Plan for Delivery of Increased Choice for Parents on Education Provision at Primary Level' (available here: https://assets.gov.ie/static/documents/09ad91e7/Framework_and_Action_Plan.pdf).

The initial focus of the framework and action plan is an online, school-specific survey. This Primary School Survey launched on 4 November and ran to 16 December 2025.

The survey – the largest of its kind ever undertaken in Ireland – was school specific and, through its results, aims to enable the department to assess demand and preferences for different types of primary school provision including patronage/ethos, co-education or single-sex school provision and language of instruction (English or Irish). Through the survey, the department has obtained clear information on the preferences of parents and guardians about the primary schools which their children currently attend, or will attend in coming years, and also from primary school staff and board of management members on their preferences for the school that they work in, on these important areas of primary school provision.

The parental survey was for:

- parents and guardians of children attending primary school; and
- parents and guardians of children not yet in school.

A separate survey was made available for:

- primary school staff; and
- members of boards of management of primary schools.

The department committed to publishing initial high-level summary results focussing on response rates in early 2026. The high-level summary response rates along with the survey preferences are contained in this report.

This report sets out a high-level summary in respect of the preferences of the parents and guardians with children in primary school and also in respect of the parents and guardians of children not yet in primary school.

Section 2 of this report provides an overview of the total number of responses received, the validation process undertaken and the total number of responses and response rate after the validation process was completed.

Section 3 gives an overview of the high-level national results in respect of the preferences of parents and guardians who submitted a validated response and also provides a county-level breakdown.

Section 4 provides a summary of the high-level results for the school staff and Board of Management member survey. Results from staff and Board of Management surveys at individual school level are not being provided in the reports for schools, to protect the privacy of staff and Board of Management members, especially in smaller schools.

While this report provides a high-level national picture and county breakdown, it is important to note that it is the preferences within each individual school community that determines future direction. Demand for change, or continuity, varies from school to school. A good response rate at individual school level is also relevant in assessing the parental preferences. Primary schools received their school-specific reports which includes the preferences of the parents and guardians with children in the school and also includes the preferences of the parents and guardians of potential future pupils[1].

Where references to parents or households is included in this report, this also refers to guardians.

[1] School-specific reports do not include the preferences of the parents of incoming pupils where no responses were received or the number of responses received was insufficient to avoid potentially disproportionately distorting the results for the school. However, these preferences are included in the figures in this report and in the School Planning Area level data on gov.ie.

2 Primary School Survey - Response Rates

2.1 Response rate before validation

The collection instrument was designed as a national census-style online consultation and was open to all eligible members of primary school communities (as set out in the introduction to this report) during the survey period from 4 November to 16 December 2025.

The parental survey was for parents and guardians of children attending primary school and parents and guardians of children not yet in school. The population frame for the parental survey was defined using administrative data sources. Specifically, it comprised unique Eircodes identified through:

The Primary Online Database (POD), in respect of children currently enrolled in primary school; and

Child Benefit administrative records, where payment was being made in respect of children aged under 13 years.

The union of these datasets formed the target population of 485,482 eligible households.

A separate survey was made available for primary school staff and members of boards of management of primary schools. The staff and board of management survey was directed at 84,285 primary school staff and board members nationally.

No probabilistic sampling approach was applied. However, the use of a clearly defined administrative population frame ensures that response rates are calculated against a known and comprehensive denominator. The survey was made available online to all eligible participants within the defined population frame. Participation was voluntary and supported by a national communications strategy designed to maximise awareness and encourage engagement across school communities.

Schools played a central role in promoting the survey. Principals were asked to circulate survey information to parents and guardians through existing school communication systems. In addition, the Department of Social Protection issued a push notification to Child Benefit recipients, registered on mywelfare.ie with children aged 12 and under, encouraging participation.

During the survey period, 241,301 responses were received from parents and guardians, representing 49.7% of eligible households prior to validation. Response

volumes varied across the survey window. The maximum number of responses received on a single day was 21,902, and the minimum number of responses received on a single day was 871. The mean number of responses per day was 5,612. Submissions were structured to allow one retained response per eligible household, with appropriate provisions made for households in non-standard accommodation settings. Further details of the validation process are set out in Section 2.2.

A total of 32,999 responses were submitted to the primary school staff and board of management survey. Following validation, 32,901 valid responses were retained for analysis, representing 39.0% of the eligible staff and board of management member population. Further details are provided in Section 4.

The department wishes to sincerely thank parents, guardians, school staff, board of management members and school leaders for their high level of engagement and participation in the survey.

2.2 Validation process and results

The survey instrument was designed to be simple, straight-forward and user friendly.

The department put in place robust, multi-layered arrangements to ensure the integrity and security of the survey process. Validation was conducted after survey responses were received. This approach ensured ease of access and usability for respondents while enabling comprehensive background validation, including the identification of multiple submissions.

The Eircode associated with the primary school attended by the child was a key element of the validation process. Submitted Eircodes were checked against the department's Primary Online Database (POD) in respect of primary school children and Child Benefit data in respect of children not yet in school to ensure that the responses were from households with primary school children or from households with children not yet in school.

All survey responses were subject to a structured validation process to ensure that submissions were genuine, unique, and met the eligibility criteria. The full process is illustrated in Figure 1.

First, the respondent's Eircode was checked against the ECAD[2] database, filtered to residential and hospitality addresses only. Responses associated with invalid or ineligible Eircodes were rejected at this stage.

Second, a duplicate submission check was carried out to ensure that each valid Eircode was associated with only one survey response. Any duplicate submissions were rejected.

Third, responses that passed these initial checks underwent an automated integrity screening. This screening examined response patterns and related indicators to identify submissions that may not be genuine. Responses flagged through this process were rejected.

Finally, responses were assessed against the eligibility criteria based on the respondent's declared child status:

Where a respondent indicated they had a child currently in school, the submission was checked against the Primary Online Database (POD).

Where a respondent indicated they had a child not yet in school, the submission was checked against Child Benefit records.

Where both applied, the submission was checked against both data sources, and a match in either was sufficient for validation.

Responses indicating no children in primary school and no younger children were deemed ineligible and rejected.

Only responses that successfully passed all relevant validation stages were classified as validated.

Table 1 and Figure 2 provide a high-level summary of the validation outcomes. In total, 241,301 survey submissions were received. Following the validation process described above, 200,381 submissions (83.0%) were validated, while 40,920 submissions (17.0%) were deemed invalid.

Most invalid submissions (85.6%) arose due to duplicate entries associated with Eircodes that had already been used to submit a response. A smaller proportion were invalidated because the Eircode, while structurally valid, could not be linked to the relevant administrative data sources (7.4%), or because the Eircode was identified as invalid (7.0%).

[2] Eircode Address Database

This distribution indicates that the majority of invalid submissions arose from repeat participation attempts rather than eligibility or verification failures. Duplicate submissions accounted for 35,032 of the 40,920 invalid responses. These duplicates were associated with 31,072 unique Eircodes.

Further analysis of duplicate cases examined whether repeated submissions were consistent in terms of key preference responses. Respondents were asked three binary preference questions relating to:

Co-education or single-sex school preference

Patronage/ethos preference [denominational (religious) patron or multi-denominational (non-religious) patron]

Language preference (education through English or through Irish)

Of the 31,072 unique Eircodes flagged for duplication, 26,481 (85%) submitted responses that were fully consistent across these three questions. In these cases, the retained submission and the rejected duplicate expressed identical preferences.

In the remaining cases (15%), the duplicate submission differed from the retained response on at least one of the three preference questions. As outlined in Figure 1, only the first valid submission associated with an Eircode was retained.

Table 1 – validation results summary

Validation result	Eircodes	Percentage
Valid response	200,381	83.0%
Eircode valid, but not linked to POD or Child Benefit data	3,041	1.3%
Eircode valid, but is a duplicate	35,032	14.5%
Eircode is invalid	2,847	1.2%

** Duplicate submissions accounted for 35,032 of the 40,920 invalid responses. These duplicates were associated with 31,072 unique Eircodes. Of the 31,072 unique Eircodes, 26,481 (85%) submitted responses that were fully consistent across the three questions - in these cases, the retained submission and the rejected duplicate expressed identical preferences and only one submission was retained. In the remaining cases (15%), the duplicate submission differed from the retained response on at least one of the three preference questions - in these cases, only the first valid submission associated with an Eircode was retained.*

The validation process along with the overall survey design were ultimately in place to maximise both participation and statistical reliability. By applying structured validation checks to all submissions, the department ensured that only eligible, unique and verified responses were included in the final dataset.

Following validation, 200,381 responses were retained for analysis. This represents 41.3% of all eligible households and constitutes a very large analytical base for a national survey of this nature.

The response rate by county is presented in Figure 3, illustrating the geographic spread of validated responses. County-level response rates ranged from 31.5% (Louth) to 63.4% (Meath). Higher response rates were observed in parts of the Midlands and West, including Meath (63.4%), Leitrim (60.4%), Kilkenny (57.4%), Galway (55.1%) and Clare (51.7%), while lower rates were concentrated in the north-east and parts of the south-east, including Louth (31.5%), Cavan (33.2%), and Waterford (34.5%). Dublin (39.9%) and Cork (39.6%), the two largest counties, recorded mid-range response rates. Despite this variation in participation levels, the absolute number of responses was large in most counties, particularly Dublin (52,986), Cork (21,715), Galway (11,708) and Meath (10,631), providing strong statistical precision for county-level estimates.

From a statistical perspective, a response base of this scale provides a high degree of precision in describing the preferences of validated respondents. At national level, the achieved response base is equivalent to a margin of error of approximately ±0.2 percentage points at the 95% confidence level under a simple random sampling assumption and maximum variability ($p = 0.5$). While the survey was not based on a probabilistic sample, this illustrates that sampling variability is very low at national level given the scale of participation. The overall margin of error is included in the school-specific reports, which the department sent to all primary schools. The approach to the overall margin of error is based on standard industry practice and uses the most conservative assumptions, giving the broadest possible margin of error across the survey questions.

In addition, the high proportion of duplicate submissions that were internally consistent (85%) strongly suggests that repeat submissions were not associated with systematic changes in expressed preferences. The validation framework ensured that only one response per eligible household was retained, thereby preserving the integrity of the dataset.

Taken together, the scale of participation and the multi-layered validation controls provide a robust and reliable foundation for subsequent analysis at national, regional, local and school level.

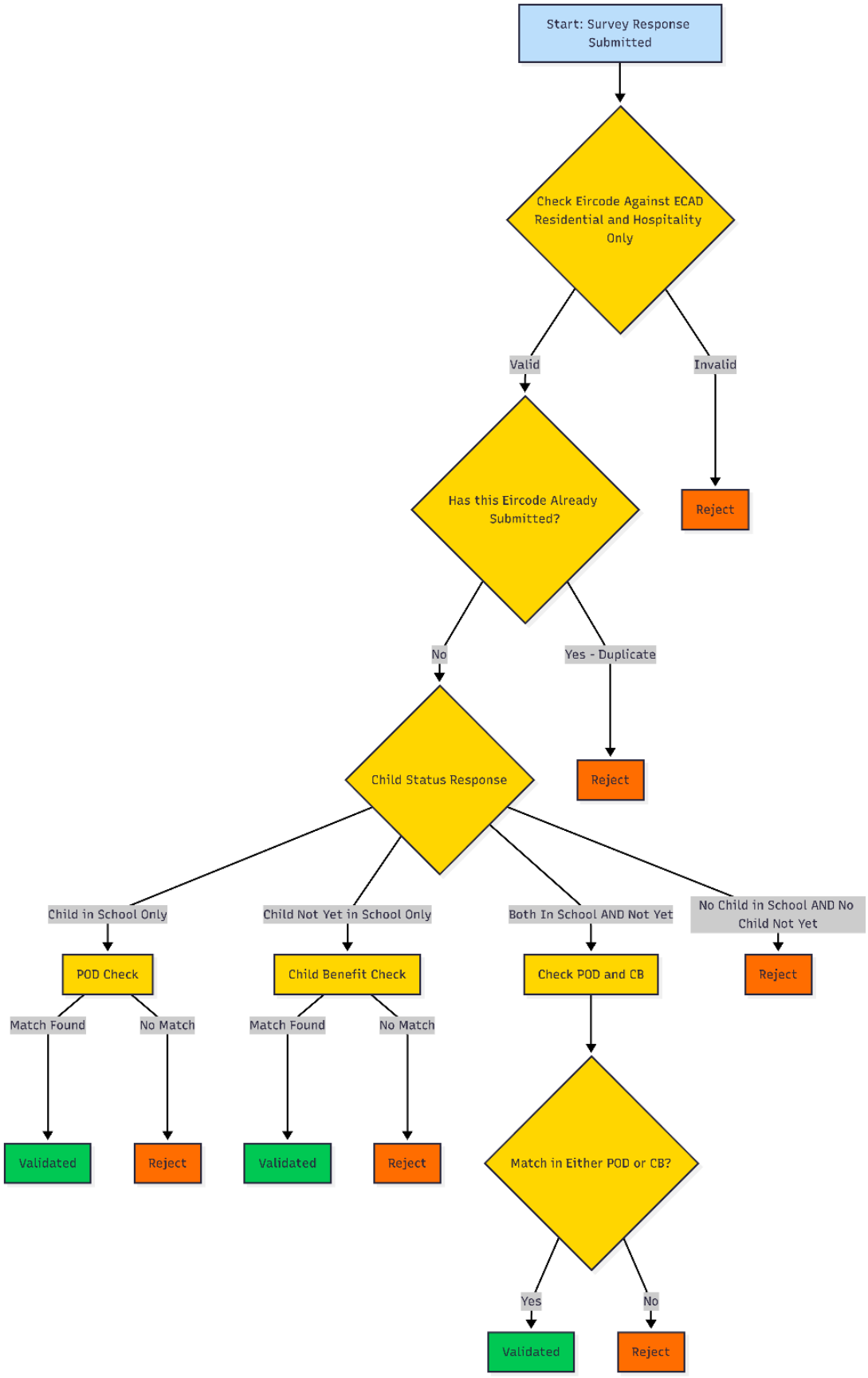


Figure 1 – Validation flow diagram

Primary School Survey 2025

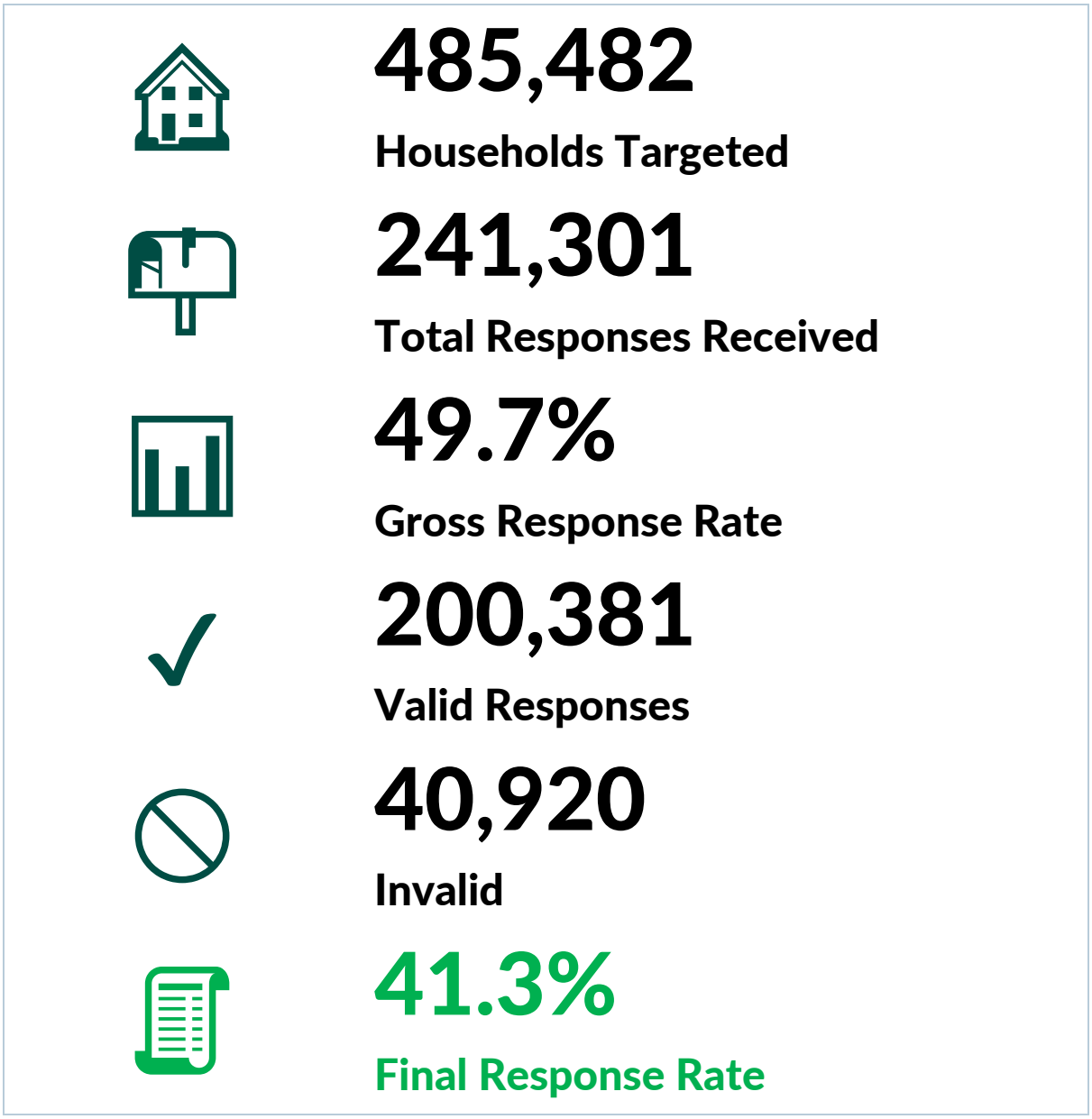


Figure 2 - Summary of Primary School Survey 2025 Validation Process

** This corresponds to 201,929 total responses when linked to schools on POD, as households associated with multiple schools on POD (i.e. with multiple children enrolled in separate schools) had their responses counted towards all schools*

***Response rate was validated by February 2026 prior to detailed analysis commencing of the survey returns.*

****see Table 1*

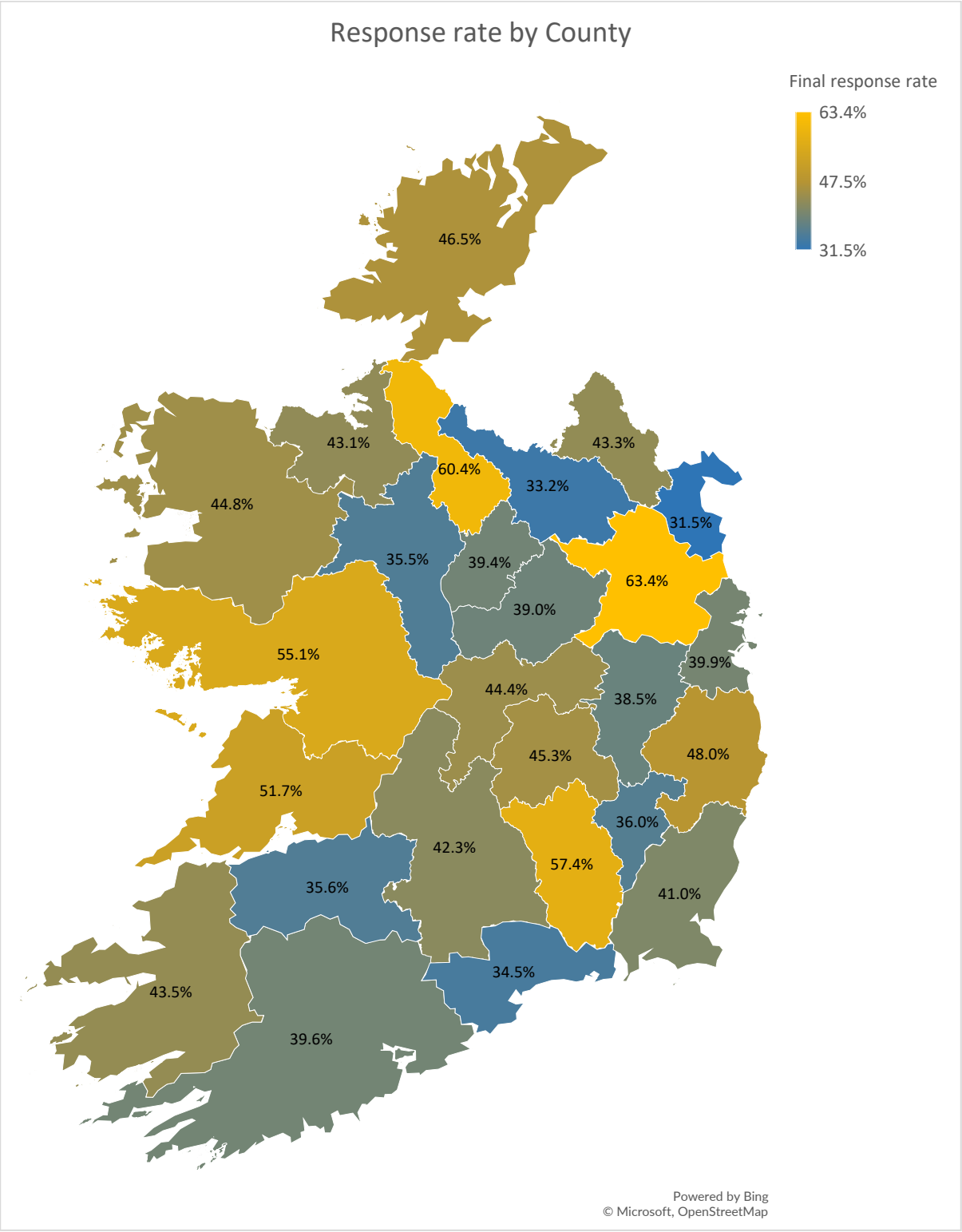


Figure 3 – County level breakdown of household response rate. Annex 1 contains the number of responses by county, by household

3 Parental Preferences

The national results presented in this section provide an overall picture of household preferences. Local, county-level and school-specific patterns may vary from the national figures.

3.1 National Level

Following validation, the survey provides a substantial analytical base for examining parents' and guardians' preferences on primary school provision. Some variation was observed by household type. Table 2a provides a national summary of responses, with a breakdown by household type, while Table 2b summarises demand for change among the subset of households for whom the stated preference would represent a change from the current or intended school configuration.

3.1.1 Co-education preference

Most schools in Ireland are co-educational, catering for both boys and girls in the same school. Nevertheless, approximately 13% of children attend schools that are entirely single-sex or have mixed junior standards[3] and single-sex senior standards[4]. Within the Primary School Survey, 14.3% of responses were linked to a single-sex school[5] (20,794 out of 145,702 households).

Nationally, amongst responding households with children attending single-sex primary schools, 73.5% (15,300 out of 20,794 households) expressed a preference for co-educational configuration. When examining only those schools that are fully single-sex, 71.7% of responding households (12,574 out of 17,521) expressed a preference to reconfigure to a co-educational school.

Amongst households with children not yet in school, who indicated that they intend to enrol their children in a single-sex school in the future, 76.6% (4,204 out of 5,487 households) selected co-educational as their preferred option. Amongst all household responses with a child not yet in school, 95.2% (53,534 out of 56,227) expressed a preference for co-educational provision. Table 4 in section 3.3 provides further breakdowns of co-educational preference by household type and county.

[3] "Junior standards" generally means Junior Infants to second class

[4] "Senior standards" generally means third through sixth class

[5] This includes schools that are entirely single-sex or have mixed junior standards and single-sex senior standards.

Combining the preferences of parents with children in single-sex schools (who have expressed a preference for a co-educational configuration) with the preferences of parents who have indicated their intent to enrol their children in single-sex schools (who have expressed a preference for a co-educational configuration), the overall demand for change to a co-educational configuration from these parents is 74.2% (19,504 out of 26,274 households).

3.1.2 Multi-denominational preference

Amongst responses from households with children in primary school, 88.0% (128,156 out of 145,702) were linked to a Catholic ethos school, 8.4% (12,179 out of 145,702) were linked to a multi-denominational ethos school and 2.6% (3,857 out of 145,702) were linked to a Church of Ireland ethos school. The remaining 1.0% (1,510) were linked to schools with another religious ethos, that is, Presbyterian, Methodist, Jewish, Muslim, Quaker or schools with an inter-denominational ethos (for example a school with a Catholic patron and a Church of Ireland patron). This broadly reflects current enrolment patterns: 88.4% of primary school children are enrolled in Catholic ethos schools, 7.7% in multi-denominational schools, 2.9% in Church of Ireland schools and 1.0% across the remaining primary schools.

Nationally, for responding households linked to a denominational school, 40.2% (53,735 out of 133,523) selected multi-denominational as their preferred ethos configuration for their school. For households linked to an existing multi-denominational school, 84.9% of households (10,338 out of 12,179) selected multi-denominational ethos/patronage as their preference.

For households with a child not yet in school, 90.7% (50,980 out of 56,227) indicated that they intend to enrol their child in a denominational school in the future. Of this figure, 42% (21,464 out of 50,980) expressed a preference for the denominational school to change to a multi-denominational ethos. Amongst those who selected a multi-denominational school as their intended future school, 86.5% (4,543 out of 5,247) selected multi-denominational ethos/patronage as their preference.

Combining the preferences of parents with children in denominational schools (who have expressed a preference for multi-denominational) with the preferences of parents who have indicated their intent to enrol their children in denominational schools (who have expressed a preference for multi-denominational), the overall demand for change to a multi-denominational ethos from these parents is 40.7%.

3.1.3 Language preference

Nationally, of responses from households with children in primary school, 91.5% (133,428 out of 145,702) were from households with children attending schools which teach through English. Of these, 13.3% (17,740 out of 133,428) expressed a preference for their school to teach through Irish. Among responding households with children in a school which teaches through Irish, 89.6% (10,999 out of 12,274) expressed a preference for the school to continue to teach through Irish. Among households with a child not yet in school, 12.3% (6,916 out of 56,227) selected a school which teaches through Irish as their intended future school. Of these responses, 94.3% (6,519 out of 6,916) expressed a preference for the school to teach through Irish. For the 87.6% of households with a child not yet in school that selected a school which teaches through English as their future school, 15.8% (7,791 out of 49,311) expressed a preference for the school to teach through Irish.

Combining the preferences of parents with children in schools that teach through English (who have expressed a preference for Irish) with the preferences of parents who have indicated their intent to enrol their children in schools which teach through English (who have expressed a preference for Irish), the overall demand for change to Irish from these parents is 13.9%.

Table 2a – Summary of household preferences with breakdown by household type

Household Type	Responses	Configuration Preference		Ethos Preference		Language Preference	
		Co-educational	Single-Sex	Multi-Denominational	Denominational	English	Irish
ALL	**200,381**	**189,083**	**11,298**	**90,189**	**110,192**	**156,091**	**44,290**
Households with children not yet in primary school only	66,403	62,205	4,198	31,220	35,183	49,225	17,178
Households with children in primary school only	107,948	102,154	5,794	47,374	60,574	86,571	21,377
Households with both children in primary school and younger children	26,030	24,724	1,306	11,595	14,435	20,295	5,735
		Proportions					
ALL	**200,381**	**94.4%**	**5.6%**	**45.0%**	**55.0%**	**77.9%**	**22.1%**
Households with children not yet in primary school only	66,403	93.7%	6.3%	47.0%	53.0%	74.1%	25.9%
Households with children in primary school only	107,948	94.6%	5.4%	43.9%	56.1%	80.2%	19.8%
Households with both children in primary school and younger children	26,030	95.0%	5.0%	44.5%	55.5%	78.0%	22.0%

Table 2b – Summary of demand for change among relevant households

Area of provision	Relevant households included	Households preferring change	Demand for change
Co-educational configuration	Households linked to single-sex schools, or indicating an intention to enrol in a single-sex school	19,504 out of 26,274	74.2%
Multi-denominational ethos	Households linked to denominational schools, or indicating an intention to enrol in a denominational school	75,199 out of 184,503	40.7%
Education through Irish	Households linked to English-medium schools, or indicating an intention to enrol in an English-medium school	25,531 out of 182,739	13.9%

Note: Percentages are based on the relevant current or intended school context for each area of provision, rather than all validated household responses.

3.2 County level

Preferences for co-educational provision were very high in all parts of the country. For all households, the highest shares were recorded in Leitrim (98.8%), Wexford (98.3%) and Sligo (98.2%), while the lowest shares were recorded in Waterford (90.4%), Dublin (90.9%) and Cork (92.8%). County-level variation was more limited for co-educational preference than for patronage or language preference. Figure 4 shows somewhat lower shares in Dublin, Waterford and Cork, and very high shares across much of the west, north-west and south-east.

At county level, preferences for multi-denominational patronage were not uniform. For all households combined, the highest shares were recorded in Wicklow (56.5%), Dublin (52.6%) and Kildare (49.8%), while the lowest shares were recorded in Monaghan (29.4%), Longford (29.8%) and Donegal (29.9%). The county pattern was broadly similar for households with children currently in school. Among households with children not yet in primary school, the preference for multi-denominational patronage was somewhat higher nationally (47.0%) than among households with children already in school (44.0%).

Preferences for education through Irish were lower than those for multi-denominational or co-educational provision, but there was a clear west and north-west concentration. For all households, the highest shares were recorded in Galway (30.2%), Donegal (26.4%) and Kerry (26.2%), while the lowest shares were recorded in Longford (13.9%), Laois (17.4%) and Wexford (17.5%). This preference was higher nationally among households with children not yet in school (25.9%) than among households with children already in school (20.2%). At county level, this pattern was consistent, with households with children not yet in primary school recording a higher preference for education through Irish than households with children in primary school in every county.

Table 3 summarises the results by county and household type. These figures present the overall stated preferences of validated responding households and therefore the percentages in Table 3 incorporate both demand for change and demand for no change because their preferences are already being catered for in terms of co-educational, multi-denominational and Irish provision. They should be interpreted alongside Table 2b, which presents demand for change among the relevant subset of households for whom the stated preference would represent a change from the current or intended school configuration. Compared with households where children are already in primary school, households with children not yet in school were somewhat more likely to express a preference for multi-denominational patronage, more likely to express a preference for education through Irish, and slightly less likely to express a preference for co-educational provision.

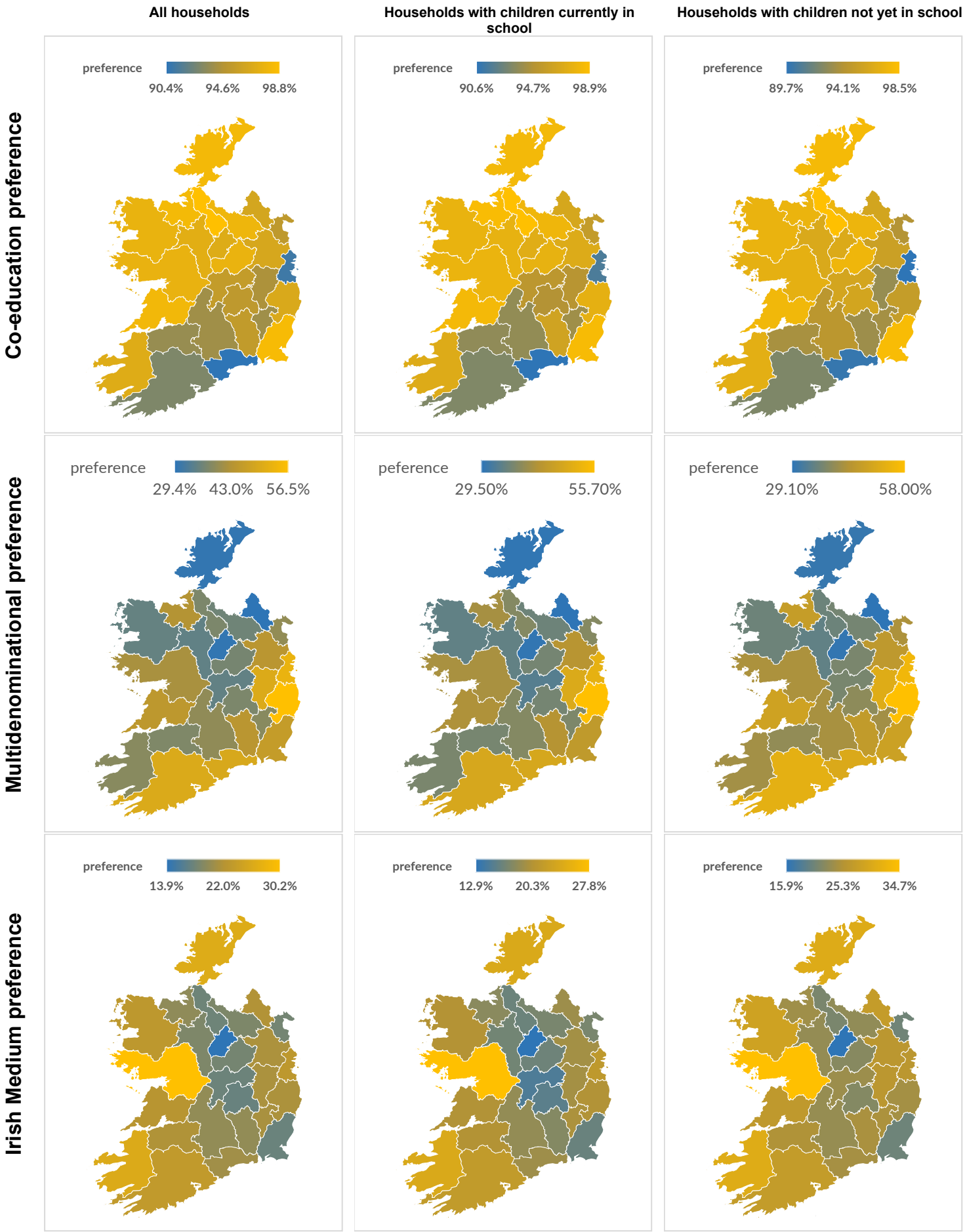


Figure 4 - Maps of preference by county and broad household type

Table 3 - Summary of preferences by county, household type

	Co-education preference			*Multi-denominational preference*			*Preference for Irish*		
COUNTY	**All households**	**Households with children in school**	**Households with children not yet in school**	**All households**	**Households with children in school**	**Households with children not yet in school**	**All households**	**Households with children in school**	**Households with children not yet in school**
CARLOW	93.9%	94.0%	93.5%	38.40%	37.10%	41.40%	21.3%	19.8%	24.6%
CAVAN	97.8%	97.9%	97.4%	35.90%	35.60%	36.60%	18.7%	17.0%	22.7%
CLARE	98.0%	98.2%	97.7%	44.20%	41.90%	48.30%	22.3%	20.1%	26.4%
CORK	92.8%	93.1%	92.3%	49.70%	48.30%	52.70%	23.2%	21.4%	27.0%
DONEGAL	98.1%	98.2%	97.9%	29.90%	29.80%	30.00%	26.4%	24.0%	30.3%
DUBLIN	90.9%	91.5%	89.7%	52.60%	51.30%	55.20%	22.8%	21.2%	25.9%
GALWAY	97.5%	97.7%	97.0%	41.70%	41.30%	42.50%	30.2%	27.8%	34.7%
KERRY	96.9%	96.9%	96.8%	38.40%	36.80%	41.50%	26.2%	23.9%	30.5%
KILDARE	94.3%	94.9%	93.1%	49.80%	49.10%	51.50%	21.4%	19.4%	25.9%
KILKENNY	95.2%	96.1%	93.3%	43.60%	42.60%	45.70%	19.9%	17.6%	24.4%
LAOIS	95.0%	94.7%	95.8%	37.20%	36.30%	39.20%	17.4%	15.3%	21.8%
LEITRIM	98.8%	98.9%	98.5%	37.20%	37.80%	35.70%	17.7%	16.2%	21.1%
LIMERICK	93.6%	93.6%	93.6%	37.50%	36.50%	39.70%	21.7%	20.2%	24.9%
LONGFORD	96.8%	97.1%	96.3%	29.80%	29.90%	29.60%	13.9%	12.9%	15.9%
LOUTH	95.0%	95.5%	94.0%	39.40%	37.90%	42.60%	18.1%	17.0%	20.4%
MAYO	97.5%	97.6%	97.2%	34.90%	34.40%	35.80%	22.9%	20.2%	28.3%
MEATH	96.4%	96.9%	95.3%	43.60%	42.90%	45.10%	21.4%	19.3%	25.9%
MONAGHAN	96.2%	96.5%	95.8%	29.40%	29.50%	29.10%	21.8%	18.9%	27.0%
OFFALY	95.3%	95.0%	95.8%	34.60%	33.40%	37.00%	17.6%	14.6%	23.5%
ROSCOMMON	97.1%	97.5%	96.2%	34.50%	34.50%	34.50%	18.7%	16.6%	22.9%
SLIGO	98.2%	98.5%	97.3%	42.80%	41.10%	46.60%	19.7%	17.9%	23.7%
TIPPERARY	93.9%	93.6%	94.4%	39.20%	37.80%	42.10%	19.9%	18.4%	23.1%
WATERFORD	90.4%	90.6%	89.9%	49.00%	48.20%	50.60%	20.8%	19.0%	24.1%
WESTMEATH	97.5%	97.5%	97.5%	36.60%	36.30%	37.20%	18.2%	16.3%	22.0%
WEXFORD	98.3%	98.4%	98.1%	45.50%	44.30%	47.80%	17.5%	16.1%	20.3%
WICKLOW	96.6%	97.4%	95.0%	56.50%	55.70%	58.00%	21.5%	20.1%	24.0%

3.3 Additional Analysis

For households with children currently in primary school, responses are grouped according to the current school attended, as identified through the department's database on schools[6], and classified by the relevant school characteristics: co-educational or single-sex school, denominational or multi-denominational ethos, and education through English or education through Irish. For households with children not yet in school, results are grouped according to the county of the responding household.

The analysis compares respondents stated preferences in the survey with the current configuration of the school attended, where applicable. While the figures provide a national and county level overview, it is important to note that it is the preferences within each individual school community that will determine future direction. Demand for change, or continuity, will vary from school to school. A good response rate at individual school level will also be relevant in assessing the parental preferences.

Table 4[7] presents the preference for co-educational provision by county and household type. Among households with children currently attending single-sex schools, preference for co-educational provision was lower than among households with children attending co-educational schools. However, most responding households with children currently attending single-sex schools expressed a preference for co-educational provision, averaging approximately three in four across counties. Among households with children not yet in school, preference for co-educational provision was also high, although somewhat lower in Dublin and Waterford than in most other counties.

Table 5[7] presents the preference for multi-denominational patronage by county and household type. Among households with children currently attending denominational schools, preference for multi-denominational patronage averaged around two in five, ranging from 29.1% in Donegal to 49.5% in Wicklow. Among households with children attending multi-denominational schools, preference for multi-denominational patronage was substantially higher, although county-level results should be interpreted with caution where the number of responding households in a given group is small. Among

[6] Primary Online Database

[7] In counties where there are no schools of a particular configuration, results are reported as "Not applicable".

households with children not yet in school, preference for multi-denominational patronage was broadly similar to that of households with children attending denominational schools, but was higher in Dublin, Kildare, Waterford and Wicklow.

Table 6 presents the preference for education through Irish by county and household type, with households grouped by whether the child currently attends a school which teaches through English, a school which teaches all subjects through Irish, or is not yet in school. Among households with children currently attending schools which teach through English, preference for education through Irish averaged 13.3% nationally. Preference for education through Irish was much higher among households with children currently attending schools which teach all subjects through Irish. Among households with children not yet in school, 24.8% expressed a preference for education through Irish, compared with 13.3% among households with children currently attending schools which teach through English. The highest preference among households with children not yet in school was recorded in Galway (33.5%), while the lowest was recorded in Longford (15.1%).

Table 4 – Preference for co-educational provision by county, household and school type

Preference for co-education among respondents ***COUNTY***	*Households with children attending single-sex schools*	*Households with children attending co-educational schools*	*Households with children not yet in school*
CARLOW	70.8%	98.0%	95.3%
CAVAN	82.2%	98.9%	97.8%
CLARE	86.7%	98.5%	98.0%
CORK	70.0%	97.9%	94.8%
DONEGAL	Not applicable	98.1%	98.4%
DUBLIN	71.3%	96.4%	92.0%
GALWAY	87.8%	98.0%	97.7%
KERRY	69.0%	98.6%	97.7%
KILDARE	79.3%	98.0%	95.8%
KILKENNY	74.2%	98.1%	95.1%
LAOIS	66.0%	96.9%	95.8%
LEITRIM	Not applicable	98.9%	99.4%
LIMERICK	63.5%	97.3%	95.2%
LONGFORD	73.3%	97.8%	97.7%
LOUTH	67.2%	97.2%	96.2%
MAYO	Not applicable	97.7%	97.7%
MEATH	76.8%	98.2%	97.0%
MONAGHAN	82.3%	98.3%	98.2%
OFFALY	78.5%	98.1%	97.2%
ROSCOMMON	72.3%	97.9%	97.6%
SLIGO	Not applicable	98.4%	98.1%
TIPPERARY	73.5%	97.3%	94.9%
WATERFORD	62.7%	98.3%	91.9%
WESTMEATH	74.4%	97.9%	98.1%
WEXFORD	Not applicable	98.4%	98.8%
WICKLOW	78.2%	97.9%	97.1%

Table 5 – Preference for multi-denominational patronage by county, household and school type

Preference for multi-denominational patronage among respondents ***COUNTY***	*Households with children attending denominational schools*	*Households with children attending multi-denominational schools*	*Households with children not yet in school*
CARLOW	35.3%	86.7%	36.2%
CAVAN	34.5%	66.7%	37.2%
CLARE	41.0%	85.7%	44.6%
CORK	45.0%	86.1%	49.4%
DONEGAL	29.1%	76.9%	27.5%
DUBLIN	43.7%	84.1%	53.3%
GALWAY	38.4%	86.4%	39.9%
KERRY	36.4%	83.3%	37.4%
KILDARE	44.1%	81.7%	51.0%
KILKENNY	40.6%	90.9%	44.0%
LAOIS	34.2%	77.9%	35.8%
LEITRIM	37.8%	Not applicable	34.6%
LIMERICK	35.0%	81.5%	36.5%
LONGFORD	29.5%	Not applicable	27.9%
LOUTH	36.2%	76.8%	39.4%
MAYO	33.7%	91.2%	33.6%
MEATH	38.9%	77.5%	43.6%
MONAGHAN	29.5%	43.3%	27.4%
OFFALY	31.7%	71.9%	33.6%
ROSCOMMON	34.2%	Not applicable	32.9%
SLIGO	40.8%	68.4%	43.0%
TIPPERARY	37.9%	65.9%	38.4%
WATERFORD	45.5%	88.8%	49.1%
WESTMEATH	35.3%	63.3%	34.5%
WEXFORD	41.6%	82.9%	45.1%
WICKLOW	49.5%	81.9%	58.2%

Table 6 – Preference for education through Irish by county, household and school type

Preference for Irish among respondents ***COUNTY***	*Households with children attending English schools*	*Households with children attending schools which teach all subjects through Irish*	*Households with children not yet in school*
CARLOW	13.9%	91.2%	21.5%
CAVAN	15.3%	79.6%	21.1%
CLARE	15.1%	93.9%	24.1%
CORK	12.2%	88.0%	27.0%
DONEGAL	14.7%	84.9%	27.1%
DUBLIN	13.5%	93.3%	25.9%
GALWAY	14.9%	87.3%	33.5%
KERRY	15.0%	86.5%	30.0%
KILDARE	12.5%	89.7%	23.5%
KILKENNY	13.9%	91.2%	22.8%
LAOIS	12.5%	84.1%	19.0%
LEITRIM	12.2%	87.8%	19.1%
LIMERICK	13.0%	85.3%	24.1%
LONGFORD	11.7%	85.7%	15.1%
LOUTH	12.7%	90.2%	19.5%
MAYO	14.5%	84.3%	24.6%
MEATH	13.4%	88.4%	24.0%
MONAGHAN	11.3%	87.9%	24.1%
OFFALY	12.1%	85.5%	18.9%
ROSCOMMON	13.7%	92.1%	21.5%
SLIGO	15.5%	90.6%	20.7%
TIPPERARY	12.8%	92.0%	23.0%
WATERFORD	11.2%	92.2%	23.8%
WESTMEATH	12.0%	88.2%	20.3%
WEXFORD	13.2%	92.0%	20.5%
WICKLOW	13.0%	92.3%	24.0%

4 School Staff and Board of Management Members Preferences

4.1 Response rates

The school staff and board of management member survey was made available to primary school staff and members of boards of management nationally. The target population for this survey was 84,285 staff and board of management members.

A total of 32,999 responses were submitted. Following validation, 32,901 valid responses were retained for analysis. This represents a final validated response rate of 39.0% of the eligible staff and board of management population.

A small number of submitted responses were excluded during validation. These exclusions represented approximately 0.3% of all submitted responses and did not materially affect the overall analytical base.

4.2 National level results

Nationally, staff and board of management member responses showed a very strong preference for co-educational provision. A majority expressed a preference for denominational patronage and education through English, while 34.7% expressed a preference for multi-denominational patronage and 13.5% expressed a preference for education through Irish.

Table 7 presents the high-level national results. Across all valid staff and board of management member responses, 94.2% expressed a preference for co-educational provision, 34.7% expressed a preference for multi-denominational patronage, and 13.5% expressed a preference for education through Irish. The overall pattern was broadly similar to the parent and guardian survey in respect of co-educational provision, with very high levels of support for co-education. Compared with parent and guardian respondents, staff and board of management member respondents expressed a lower preference for multi-denominational patronage and a lower preference for education through Irish.

Table 7 – high level results for staff / boards of management members.

PREFERENCE	RESPONSES	PERCENTAGE
CO-EDUCATIONAL	30,977	94.2%
SINGLE-SEX	1,924	5.8%
DENOMINATIONAL	21,469	65.3%
MULTI-DENOMINATIONAL	11,432	34.7%
EDUCATION THROUGH ENGLISH	28,474	86.5%
EDUCATION THROUGH IRISH	4,427	13.5%

4.3 Results by current school configuration

Preference for co-educational provision varied by the current configuration of the school. Among respondents associated with co-educational schools, 99.3% expressed a preference for co-educational provision. Among respondents associated with single-sex schools, including single-sex schools with mixed junior standards, 59.3% expressed a preference for co-educational provision. This indicates that, while preference for co-education was very high overall, it was lower among respondents associated with schools currently operating under a single-sex configuration.

Preferences on patronage varied strongly by the current ethos configuration of the school. Among respondents associated with denominational schools, 31.6% expressed a preference for multi-denominational patronage. Among respondents associated with multi-denominational schools, 93.7% expressed a preference for multi-denominational patronage. This indicates a strong association between current school context and respondent preference.

Preferences on language also varied by the current language configuration of the school. Among respondents associated with schools which teach through English, 7.9% expressed a preference for education through Irish. Among respondents associated with schools which teach through Irish, 84.9% expressed a preference for education through Irish. As with patronage, this indicates a strong association between current school context and respondent preference.

4.4 County-level results

Preference for co-educational provision was high across all counties. The highest shares were recorded in Clare, Sligo, Mayo, Leitrim and Donegal, each above 99.5%. The lowest shares were recorded in Waterford, Monaghan, Carlow, Dublin and Cork. Even in the counties with lower shares, a substantial majority of staff and board of management respondents expressed a preference for co-educational provision.

County-level variation was more pronounced in respect of patronage. The highest shares expressing a preference for multi-denominational patronage were recorded in Dublin, Cork, Wicklow, Waterford and Wexford. The lowest shares were recorded in Longford, Leitrim, Monaghan, Roscommon and Westmeath. This pattern indicates stronger preference for multi-denominational patronage among staff and board of management member respondents in Dublin and several larger urban or commuter counties, and lower preference in parts of the Midlands and border counties.

Preference for education through Irish showed clearer regional variation than preference for co-educational provision. The highest shares were recorded in Galway, Kerry, Donegal and Mayo, reflecting comparatively stronger preference for education through Irish in parts of the west and north-west. The lowest shares expressing a preference for education through Irish were recorded in Roscommon, Longford, Laois, Offaly and Cavan.

5 Summary

Taken together, the results show substantial engagement with the Primary School Survey across parents and guardians, school staff, and board of management members. The findings provide a strong high-level evidence base on expressed preferences for primary school provision nationally and by county. The school-specific reports, which show the preferences within each individual school community, will determine future direction. Demand for change, or continuity, varies from school to school. A good response rate at individual school level is also relevant in assessing the parental preferences. On 4 June, primary schools received a school-specific report with the preferences of the parents and guardians with children in the school and the preferences of the parents and guardians of potential future pupils.

Table 8 - Staff and board of management member preferences by county

COUNTY	RESPONSES	CO-EDUCATIONAL PREFERENCE	MULTI-DENOMINATIONAL PREFERENCE	EDUCATION THROUGH IRISH PREFERENCE
CARLOW	447	89.9%	26.2%	15.0%
CAVAN	621	97.9%	25.4%	8.9%
CLARE	792	99.9%	31.9%	9.2%
CORK	3,702	91.4%	42.1%	13.1%
DONEGAL	1,427	99.6%	22.9%	20.4%
DUBLIN	7,114	90.2%	43.3%	12.7%
GALWAY	2,077	98.7%	34.0%	23.5%
KERRY	1,094	97.4%	24.9%	20.8%
KILDARE	1,354	93.7%	38.8%	13.4%
KILKENNY	719	97.6%	33.0%	9.6%
LAOIS	730	91.8%	25.5%	8.2%
LEITRIM	357	99.7%	19.3%	13.2%
LIMERICK	1,462	91.9%	31.9%	12.4%
LONGFORD	470	97.0%	19.1%	7.4%
LOUTH	991	94.9%	34.6%	13.2%
MAYO	1,098	99.7%	26.4%	16.2%
MEATH	1,400	98.3%	35.6%	13.4%
MONAGHAN	451	88.9%	20.8%	13.3%
OFFALY	692	92.5%	24.7%	8.2%
ROSCOMMON	685	98.1%	22.5%	6.3%
SLIGO	466	99.8%	31.5%	11.8%
TIPPERARY	1,178	91.9%	32.9%	10.6%
WATERFORD	900	82.9%	39.3%	13.0%
WESTMEATH	755	98.1%	22.8%	11.1%
WEXFORD	1,032	99.3%	39.1%	10.8%
WICKLOW	887	96.4%	41.0%	12.9%

Annex 1 – Valid parental survey responses by county, household type

COUNTY	TOTAL VALID RESPONSES	HOUSEHOLDS WITH CHILDREN IN SCHOOL*	HOUSEHOLDS WITH CHILDREN NOT YET IN SCHOOL**
CARLOW	2,347	1,623	724
CAVAN	3,382	2,382	1,000
CLARE	4,688	3,045	1,643
CORK	21,392	14,551	6,841
DONEGAL	6,885	4,229	2,656
DUBLIN	52,172	34,667	17,505
GALWAY	11,502	7,525	3,977
KERRY	5,554	3,633	1,921
KILDARE	11,284	7,770	3,514
KILKENNY	4,156	2,772	1,384
LAOIS	3,932	2,696	1,236
LEITRIM	1,534	1,061	473
LIMERICK	7,632	5,177	2,455
LONGFORD	1,798	1,174	624
LOUTH	5,907	4,034	1,873
MAYO	5,618	3,782	1,836
MEATH	10,483	7,109	3,374
MONAGHAN	2,639	1,710	929
OFFALY	3,243	2,139	1,104
ROSCOMMON	3,015	2,016	999
SLIGO	2,761	1,900	861
TIPPERARY	6,084	4,154	1,930
WATERFORD	4,992	3,285	1,707
WESTMEATH	4,176	2,832	1,344
WEXFORD	6,578	4,348	2,230
WICKLOW	6,627	4,364	2,263
TOTAL	200,381	133,978	66,403

*households with children in primary school and households with both children in primary school and children not yet in school.

**households with children not yet in primary school only.

